



ANNUAL REPORT 2025/26

Programme delivery mapped against IFDC's strategic pillars, 2024–2026



Overview

IFDC's mission — to build a safer digital environment for children through education, advocacy, and multi-sector partnership — was advanced this period through four interlocking strands of work: direct prevention education in schools; a flagship response to online sexual exploitation and abuse; promotion of balanced, safe engagement with gaming and social platforms; and the deliberate build-out of an advocate, ambassador, and institutional-partnership network to sustain this work beyond any single session. Rather than a series of unconnected events, these programmes function as a single pipeline: school-based education builds awareness at the point of first exposure; the exploitation-response strand targets the most severe harms with an evidence base to match; digital-wellbeing work addresses the everyday design and behavioural pressures children face; and the capacity-building strand ensures parents, teachers, government officers, and youth advocates are equipped to carry this work forward independently of IFDC's direct presence.



IFDC's Core Programme Areas

All of IFDC's activity is delivered under four permanent, organisation-wide programme areas. These are distinct from the four thematic pillars used later in this report to group the period's specific activities: the programme areas below are IFDC's standing structure for how it works, while the pillars on the following pages describe what was actually delivered under that structure during 2025–2026.

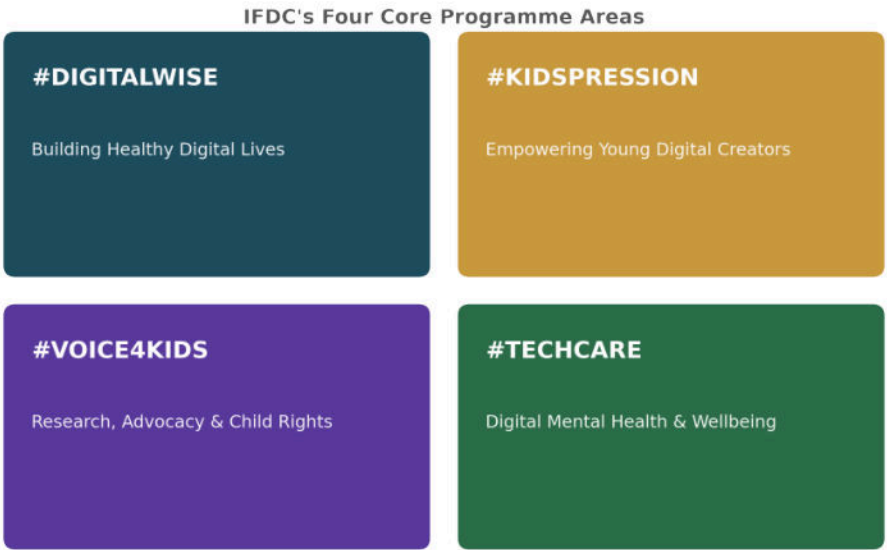


Figure 1 — IFDC's four core programme areas.

#DigitalWise — Building Healthy Digital Lives

DigitalWise equips children, parents, educators, and caregivers with the knowledge and skills to use digital technologies safely, responsibly, and confidently. Through training, mentoring, and awareness programmes, it promotes digital literacy, online safety, digital wellbeing, critical thinking, and healthy digital habits. The programme addresses major online threats, including cyberbullying, online grooming, sextortion, child sexual abuse material (CSAM), child sexual exploitation, the live streaming of child sexual abuse, harmful online content, misinformation, privacy risks, digital addiction, and AI-enabled harms, helping families build safer and healthier digital lives.

#Kidspression — Empowering Young Digital Creators

Kidspression empowers children to become creative, confident, and responsible digital citizens. Through digital storytelling, filmmaking, photography, podcasting, journalism, and other creative media, the programme nurtures children's talents and voices. Guided by the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC), it promotes children's rights to access, participation, freedom of expression, information, and creativity, while encouraging them to become active creators rather than passive consumers of digital content.

#Voice4Kids — Research, Advocacy, and Child Rights

Voice4Kids is IFDC's research and advocacy platform dedicated to advancing children's rights in the digital environment. It generates evidence on issues such as cyberbullying, online grooming, child sexual exploitation and abuse, CSAM, sextortion, the live streaming of child sexual abuse, harmful online content, digital addiction, AI-related harms, misinformation, and privacy risks to strengthen policy, improve child protection systems, promote ethical media practices, and amplify children's voices in shaping a safer digital future.

#TechCare — Advancing Digital Mental Health and Wellbeing

TechCare promotes digital mental health and healthy relationships with technology among children, young people, parents, and educators. Through research, education, mentoring, and evidence-based interventions, the programme addresses digital addiction, problematic social media use, gaming disorder, unhealthy online relationships, cyberbullying, fear of missing out (FoMO), anxiety, depression, loneliness, sleep disruption, problematic pornography consumption, digital burnout, and AI-related psychological impacts. It promotes digital resilience, healthy technology use, mindfulness, positive digital wellbeing, and balanced online lives.

Programme Delivery This Period

The remainder of this report maps specific activities delivered during 2025–2026 against four thematic pillars, each of which draws primarily on one or more of the core programme areas above.



Figure 2 — IFDC's four delivery pillars this period and programme distribution.

PILLAR 1 Prevention Education in Schools

IFDC's foundational strategy is early, direct engagement with children themselves — reaching them before harm occurs, in the environment they already trust. This pillar prioritises age-appropriate, participatory formats (short films, quizzes, storytelling) over lecture-style delivery, on the premise that recognition and reporting skills are best built through relatable scenarios rather than abstract warnings.

Cyberbullying Awareness Programme (Short Films)



Venue: Mologgamuwa Maha Vidyalaya, Kirilipana | **Audience:** Students aged 14–16

What Happened

Sessions introduced the concept of cyberbullying and distinguished it from traditional, offline bullying, before using short films as the central teaching tool. The films depicted online harassment, rumour-spreading, non-consensual sharing of private images, and hate speech on social media, giving students concrete, relatable scenarios rather than abstract definitions. Facilitators linked rising smartphone and social media access among adolescents to greater exposure to digital harm, and used the films' emotional narratives to walk students through the mental and physical health consequences of abuse — anxiety, stress, fear, low self-esteem, sleep disruption, and declining academic performance.

Impact

Facilitators reported strong active participation and a marked increase in awareness, with students demonstrating a clearer understanding of cyberbullying, its consequences, and their own responsibilities as digital citizens. The film-led format appeared to build empathy for victims more effectively than lecture delivery, and organisers noted a shift in students' stated attitudes toward safer, more respectful online conduct — reinforcing short films as a format IFDC intends to replicate in future school sessions.

Preventing Online Child Abuse



Venue: D.A. Rajapaksa Vidyalaya, Kiribathgoda | **Audience:** Grades 9, 10 & 11 | **Facilitator:** Rajapakshage Riyada Helakumara, IFDC Advocate

What Happened

The session presented the main categories of online child abuse — cyberbullying, online grooming, and exposure to harmful content — before moving into practical protective behaviours: privacy settings, pausing before sharing personal information, and reporting suspicious messages or individuals to a trusted adult or authority. Structured content delivery was paired with open discussion, giving students space to raise their own experiences.

Impact

Students reported gaining valuable new knowledge and said they would use the internet more responsibly, with many stating increased confidence identifying and reporting online risks. The session also generated useful two-way insight for IFDC: it clarified how students themselves perceive risks such as grooming, directly informing how future sessions are pitched, and sharpened the facilitator's own interactive-facilitation skills.

Seminar on Online Child Safety — Handapangoda Maha Vidyalaya

A two-hour session used a quiz-based format and storytelling techniques, rather than straight lecture delivery, to explain how online offenders target children for sexual exploitation — covering grooming, sexting, sextortion, cyber harassment, and related abuse.

Impact

The interactive format was designed to improve retention and practical understanding across a wide age range in a single sitting, and reflects IFDC's broader shift toward engagement-driven safety content rather than uniform, one-size-fits-all presentations.

Reported Experience of Cyberbullying
or Digital Extortion

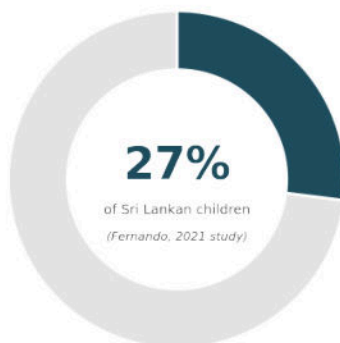


Figure 3 — Prevalence of cyberbullying/digital extortion among Sri Lankan children (Fernando, 2021), the baseline risk this pillar's school programmes respond to.

PILLAR 2 Combating Online Sexual Exploitation, Abuse & Cyberbullying

This is IFDC's most severe-harm-focused pillar: a flagship, evidence-driven response to CSAM, grooming, and sextortion, paired with large-scale, multi-agency community response programming. Where Pillar 1 builds baseline awareness, this pillar targets the specific, high-risk behaviours and reporting failures that data show are most under-addressed in Sri Lanka.



Online Sexual Exploitation of Children — Sri Lanka Context

Programme: Online Child Protection Advocates Program 2025 | **Lead:** Dr. M.C. Rasmin, IFDC Founder | **Reach:** 25 schools

What Happened

Workshops mapped the main forms of online sexual exploitation affecting Sri Lankan children — CSAM distribution, grooming, sextortion, and cyberbullying — and traced how these typically begin on social media,

messaging apps (notably WhatsApp and IMO), and online gaming platforms where children are often unsupervised. Sessions examined grooming as a deliberate, trust-building process in which perpetrators pose as mentors or friends before pressuring children into sharing explicit content, and covered sexting driven by peer pressure or predator manipulation, with cases identified among girls as young as 13. The layered, age-appropriate prevention model applied here pairs body-safety and trust education for younger children with consent and healthy-relationship discussion for adolescents.

Impact & Evidence Base

Beyond awareness, the programme pushed a specific behavioural target: parents responding to disclosures with support rather than anger or punishment, which Dr. Rasmin identified as decisive in whether children come forward at all. The data below, presented during these workshops, frames the scale of the problem this pillar exists to address.



Figure 4 — CSAM exposure and reporting gaps among children, as presented in IFDC workshops.



Figure 5 — International CSAM data used to contextualise the scale of the problem locally (Internet Watch Foundation, 2021; EUROPOL).

Training Programme: Protecting Children from Online Abuse



Date / Venue: IETI – NAITA | **Participation:** 350+ participants | **Lead:** Dr. M.C. Rasmin; coordinated by Ms. Randi Ushara

What Happened

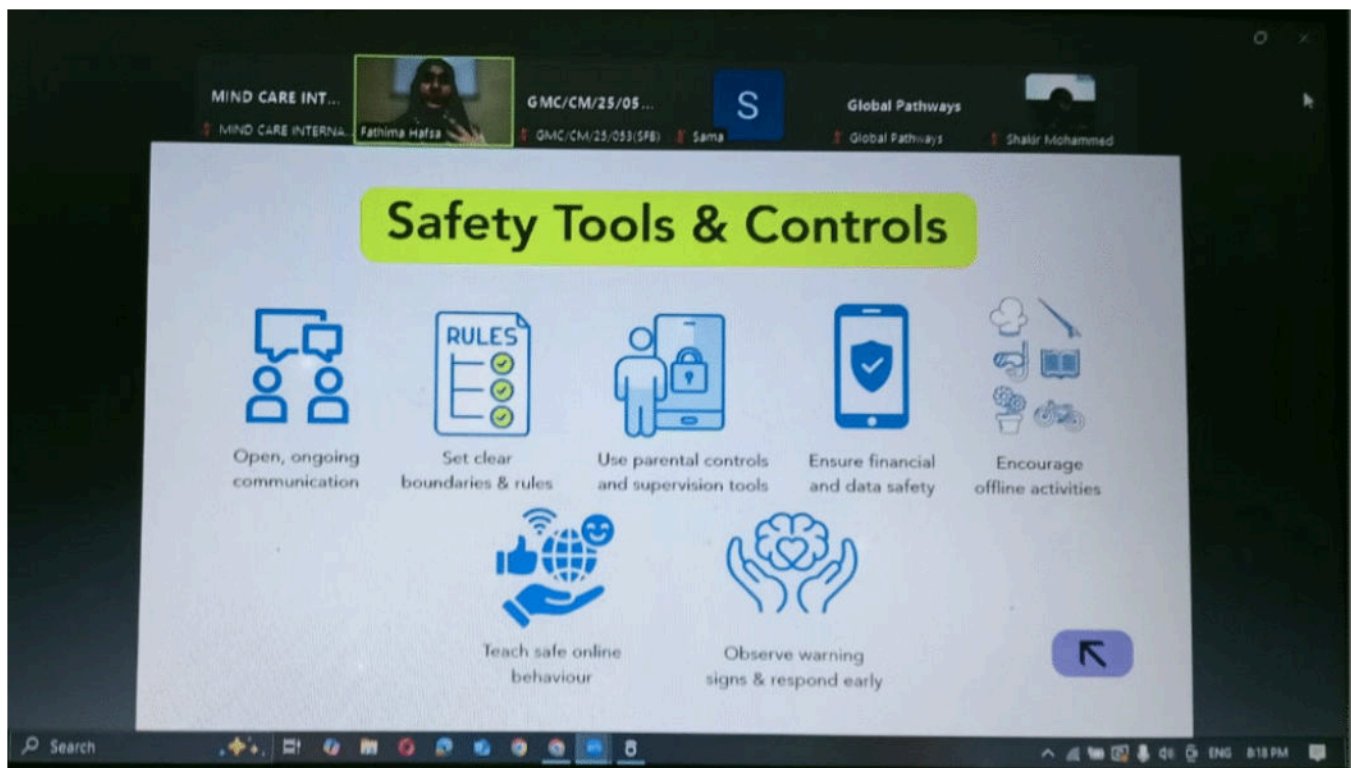
This large-scale programme convened a panel of government counselling and youth-service professionals — including officers from the Ministry of Women and Children's Affairs and Social Empowerment and the Moratuwa Divisional Secretariat — to address grooming, harassment, cyberbullying, and sextortion, alongside open-communication and proactive-intervention strategies for parents, educators, and community leaders.

Impact

At over 350 participants, this was among IFDC's largest single events of the period, reflecting significant institutional buy-in from government counselling and youth-service bodies. The interactive format encouraged cross-stakeholder collaboration, positioning the event as a step toward equipping whole communities — not just schools — to protect children's rights and wellbeing online, with further joint programming planned on the partnerships formed here.

PILLAR 3 Promoting Digital Wellbeing: Gaming, Persuasive Design & Balanced Engagement

Beyond acute risks like grooming and exploitation, IFDC treats the everyday design of digital platforms — engagement-maximising features, gaming content, and social media mechanics — as a distinct wellbeing concern in its own right. This pillar's programming deliberately balances risk-awareness with recognition of technology's genuine educational and social value, avoiding a purely restrictive message.



Mind Care Initiative: Online Gaming & Digital Safety

Partners: Mind Care International – Sri Lanka; Global Pathways | **Format:** Webinar | **Speaker:** Fathima Hafsa Haniffa (IFDC); organised by Zeenathun Nuha Ameen

What Happened

The webinar examined the types of games children commonly play, why gaming appeals to them, and the psychological and behavioural effects of exposure to violence-themed content — flagging particular concern that many children, especially boys, gravitate toward shooting and violence-themed games, with possible knock-on effects for empathy and conflict resolution. Discussion balanced this with gaming's positive potential — creativity, problem-solving, teamwork, and digital literacy in moderation — illustrated with classroom-suitable educational game examples, before covering cyberbullying and exploitation risks on gaming platforms, safety tools, parental controls, and Sri Lanka's national child-protection support system.

Impact

The webinar created an open, cross-audience space — parents, educators, students, and community members together — to reflect candidly on both the benefits and risks of gaming, rather than treating it as a problem to be simply restricted, and equipped parents and educators with tools they could apply immediately. It also reinforced IFDC's partnership model of working through mental-health and community organisations to extend reach beyond its own direct network.

Children versus Persuasive Tech



Speaker: Dr. Sumudu Mallawarachchi | **Affiliation:** ARC Centre of Excellence for the Digital Child, Deakin University

What Happened

This session unpacked persuasive design — features deliberately built into apps to maximise engagement — walking through specific tactics: variable rewards, social validation, reciprocity mechanics, ephemeral content that manufactures fear of missing out, algorithmic personalisation, infinite scrolling, and frictionless features like one-click payments. It explained why children are disproportionately susceptible, given still-developing emotional-regulation and decision-making skills, and how unchecked exposure contributes to digital addiction, privacy violations, and exposure to inappropriate content.

Impact

Rather than recommending blanket restriction, the session equipped parents and educators with a more precise response: teaching children to critically recognise persuasive design as it operates on them, modelling healthy device habits, and using existing tools (Digital Wellbeing, Screen Time, Bedtime/Focus modes, disabling autoplay). It also connected local practice to a wider regulatory push — the UK's Children's Design Code and advocacy from Common Sense Media and the Center for Humane Technology — framing platform accountability, not just individual willpower, as part of the solution IFDC advocates for.

Scroll Smart: Navigating Social Media Safely



Lead: Pehansa Wijenayaka, IFDC Advocate | **Background:** Fellow, OCSA Prevention Programme, Cohort 1

What Happened

Scroll Smart used interactive workshops, real-life examples, and scenario-based learning to cover digital literacy, online privacy, cyberbullying awareness, misinformation, screen-time management, and safeguarding personal information — deliberately pairing risk-awareness with discussion of social media's positive potential for learning, peer connection, and community advocacy. Parental and educator components gave adults tools to support open discussion of students' online experiences at home.

Impact

Schools and educators reported improved student awareness of online risks and more responsible social media behaviour following the sessions, with many students saying they now feel more confident making thoughtful choices about their online activity. IFDC's founder highlighted the initiative as a model of youth-advocate-led ownership of digital safety that the organisation intends to extend to further schools.

PILLAR 4 Building Capacity: Advocates, Ambassadors & Multi-Sector Partnerships

IFDC's long-term reach depends on people beyond its own staff — trained advocates, an ambassador network, and formal ties to government, academic, and civil-society bodies — who can carry prevention and response work forward independently. This pillar is about institution-building rather than single-session delivery, and several of the sessions above were themselves delivered by advocates or fellows this pillar produced.



International Foundation for Digital Child

ASIAN DIGITAL MENTAL HEALTH ADVOCATES FELLOWSHIP 2025/26



REGISTER
NOW

- All sessions will be delivered in English.
- Application deadline:
2nd January, 2026



Ms Zoe de Melo

THEMATIC PROGRAM MANAGER,
TERRE DES HOMMES, THE
NETHERLANDS

Speaker topic: How Digital Platforms
Can Cause Mental Health Issues in
Children and Youth: Causes and Way
Forward.



Mr Emmanuel Adinkrah

PRESIDENT, CHANA INTERNET
SAFETY FOUNDATION, AFRICA

Speaker topic: Digital Mental Health
and Safety of Children and Youth
from a Global Perspective: From
Africa to Asia.



**Dr Nicolas
Makharashvili**

DIRECTOR, SAFE FUTURES HUB,
SOUTH AFRICA

Speaker topic: Effective Prevention
of Child Sexual Violence and Abuse:
Strategies for Online and Offline
Realities.



Dr. Kanthi Hettigoda

CLINICAL PSYCHOLOGIST & SENIOR
LECTURER IN PSYCHOLOGY, DEPARTMENT
OF PSYCHOLOGY, UOP, SRI LANKA (PH.D IN
PSYCHOLOGY, M.PHIL., M.SC., B.A.)

Speaker topic: Digital Addiction and
Mental Health: Strategies for
Supporting Children and Youth



**Dr Mandy Hall-
Sanchez**

DIRECTOR OF PROGRAMMING,
CULTURE REFRAMED, USA

Speaker topic: Young People and the
Consumption of Pornography: Does It
Really Cause Mental Health Issues?

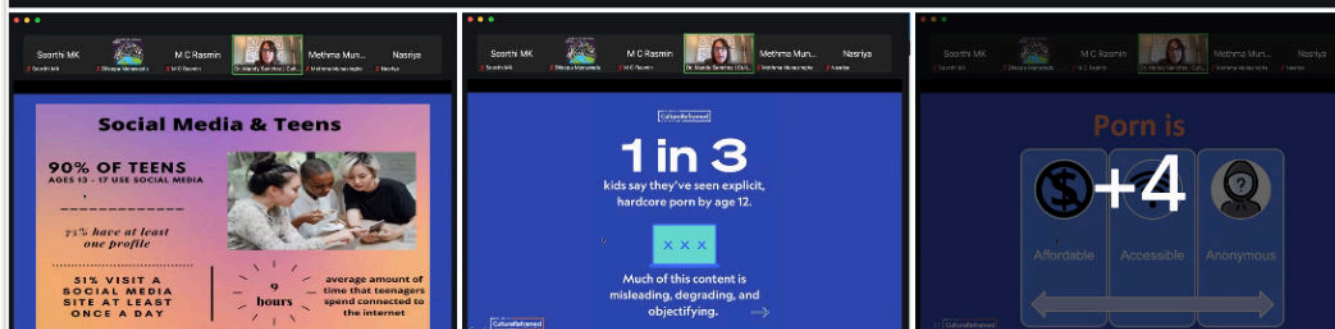
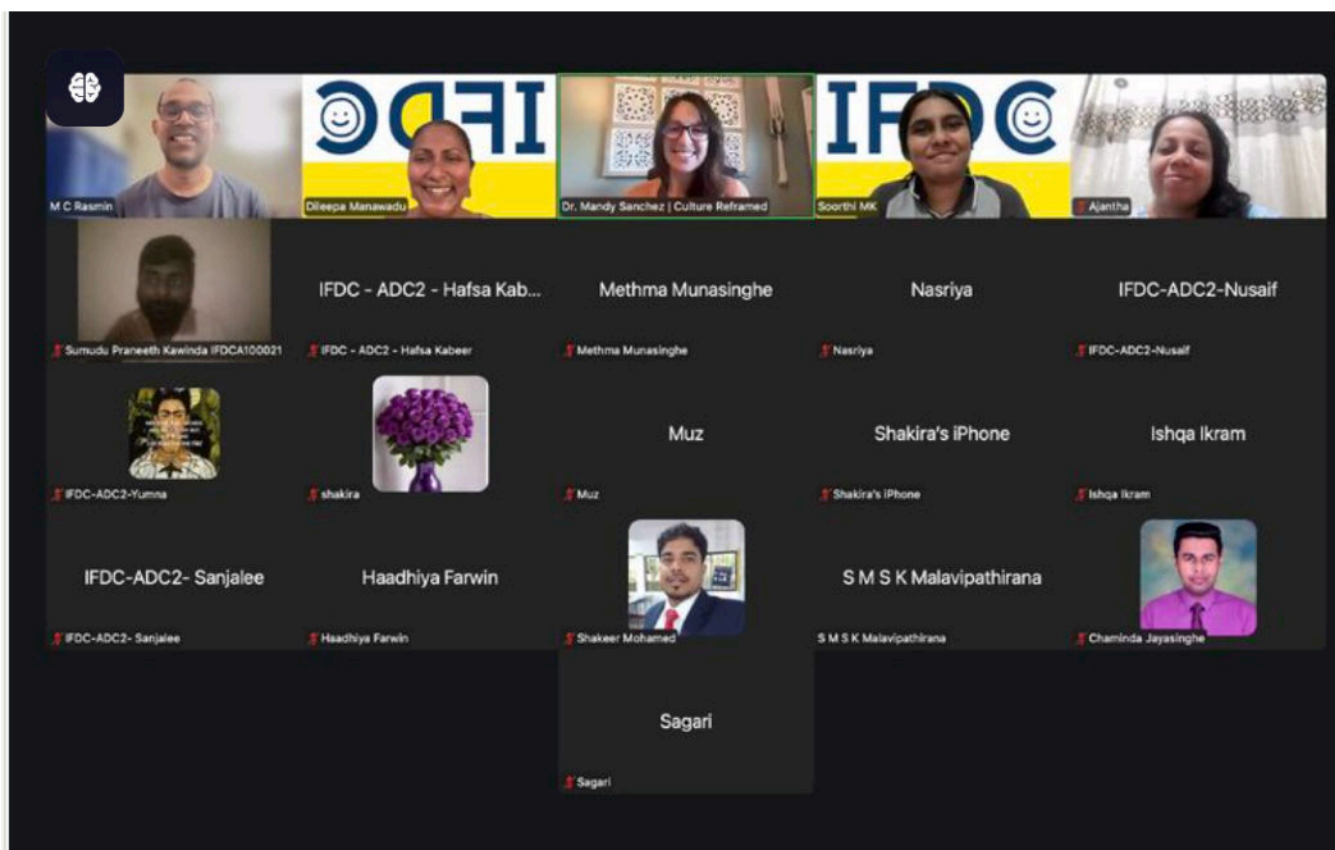


Ms Arti Mohan

LEAD TECHNICAL SPECIALIST
PRACTICE-BASED KNOWLEDGE,
SAFE FUTURES HUB, SOUTH AFRICA

Speaker topic: Effective Prevention
of Child Sexual Violence and Abuse:
Strategies for Online and Offline
Realities.

Online Child Protection Ambassador Program — Launch



Date: 25 January 2025 | **Participation:** 121 participants | **Facilitator:** Ms. Thushana Sathasivam | **Session Lead:** Ms. Pratishtha Arora, CEO, Social & Media Matters

What Happened

The inaugural virtual session of this new flagship ambassador programme, 'Understanding Online Child Sexual Abuse and Prevention Strategies,' was led by gender-studies and online-safety expert Pratishtha Arora. It covered CSAM, grooming, and the psychological effects of abuse, with particular focus on the role of trusted adults in prevention. Discussion addressed practical barriers to protection — parents underestimating the risks of oversharing children's images, and reluctance to report abuse for fear of judgement or reputational harm — and introduced the concept of a child's 'private sphere,' confidential reporting channels, and age-appropriate rights-based education for children on consent and personal boundaries.

Impact

With 121 participants at launch, the session established a strong base for an ongoing ambassador network. It set out a practical roadmap that other IFDC programmes have since built on — parent education on oversharing, trust-building between children and adults, confidential reporting mechanisms, and direct rights-based education

for children — positioning multi-sector collaboration between policymakers, educators, community leaders, and parents as the structure IFDC is deliberately building toward.

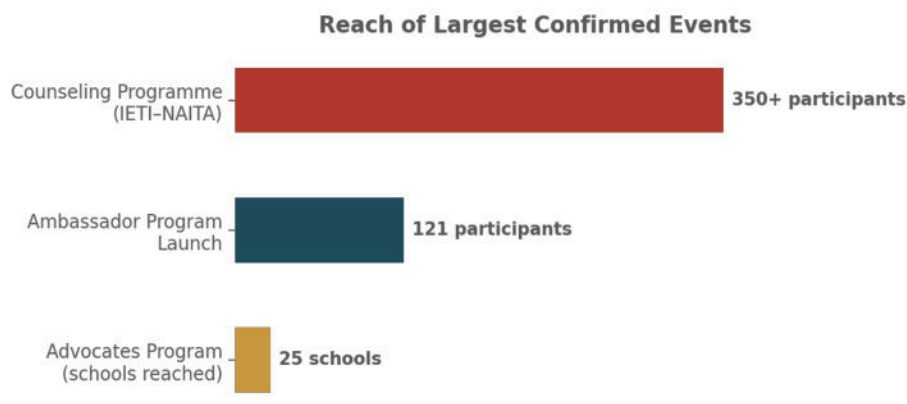


Figure 6 — Reach of the three largest confirmed-attendance events this period.

Cross-Cutting Partnerships

Capacity-building this period was not confined to the Ambassador Program alone: the Mind Care Initiative (Pillar 3) was delivered jointly with Mind Care International – Sri Lanka and Global Pathways, extending IFDC's reach through an established mental-health network; the Counseling Programme (Pillar 2) drew directly on a panel of government counselling and youth-service officers from the Ministry of Women and Children's Affairs and Social Empowerment and the Moratuwa Divisional Secretariat; and school-level sessions (Pillar 1) were themselves delivered by IFDC-trained advocates such as Rajapakshage Riyada Helakumara and Pehansa Wijenayaka. Taken together, this reflects a deliberate strategy of embedding IFDC's prevention model inside existing institutions — schools, government welfare bodies, and mental-health organisations — rather than relying solely on direct delivery.

Strategic Reflections

- Rising exposure is the shared driver across all four pillars: increased smartphone and social media access is consistently cited as the reason adolescent vulnerability to cyberbullying, grooming, and exploitation continues to grow, reinforcing the case for sustained, not one-off, programming.
- Under-reporting remains the central unresolved gap: even where awareness improved, data (only 28% of CSAM-affected children comfortable reporting) show that recognition of risk has outpaced children's and parents' willingness to disclose it.
- Prevention over punishment is a consistent operating principle: programmes across all pillars emphasised open communication and non-judgemental parental response over restriction, identifying punitive reactions as a direct barrier to disclosure.
- Engagement-driven formats outperform lecture delivery: short films, quizzes, storytelling, and scenario-based workshops were used deliberately in place of straight presentations, with facilitators reporting stronger participation and self-reported confidence gains as a result.
- Institutional embedding is now IFDC's core growth strategy: rather than scaling through headcount alone, the organisation is deliberately building out advocates, ambassadors, and formal ties into schools, government welfare bodies, and mental-health networks to sustain impact beyond direct delivery.

Financial Statement

Financial Statement

This is to confirm that the programmes implemented by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) during the 2025/26 financial year were directly funded by The Story Café. While all programme implementation and delivery were carried out entirely by IFDC, the funds were managed and administered through The Story Café's financial management system. The funding was utilised almost entirely for direct programme implementation, community outreach, and related project activities in accordance with the approved programme objectives.

The grant funding was made available under a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed between The Story Café and the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), which established the framework for programme implementation, financial management, and institutional collaboration.

Income

Funding Source	Amount (LKR)
The Story Café — Programme Support	2,175,763
Total Income	2,175,763

Expenditure

Category	Amount (LKR)	% of Total
Pillar 1: Prevention Education in Schools	870,305	40.0%
Pillar 2: Online Exploitation & Cyberbullying Response	478,668	22.0%
Pillars 3 & 4: Digital Wellbeing & Capacity Building	391,637	18.0%
Volunteer Transport & Logistics	217,576	10.0%
Communications & Digital Outreach	130,546	6.0%
Administrative & Contingency Costs	87,031	4.0%
Total Expenditure	2,175,763	100%



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